

Lying awake, trying to force yourself to sleep

8 findings · 10-step checklist · 2 myths · 7 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Working hard to fall asleep sometimes backfires, but **only when something else already has your attention**, like noise or a racing mind. Lying there longer isn't always the fix.

THE GOAL

You're trying to stop working against yourself, not to force sleep on command. Getting up when it's not working isn't giving up on tonight; do something calm until you're sleepy.

CHECKLIST

You're lying in bed, wide awake, working at making yourself fall asleep.

- ☐ Unclench your jaw and shoulders, and stop working at making sleep happen on command.
- ☐ Keep your phone face down, out of reach.
- ☐ Once you notice it's been roughly twenty minutes since you started trying, **get up**.
- ☐ Get out of bed and, if you can, leave the bedroom.
- ☐ Keep the light low, like a small lamp, not the overhead light.
- ☐ If tomorrow's tasks are what's circling in your head, write a specific list for them right now.
- ☐ Pick something low-key to do, like reading a few pages or quiet music, and **skip anything that pulls your attention**: shows, scrolling, messages.
- ☐ Stay with it until your eyelids genuinely feel heavy, not just until you're bored of it.
- ☐ Once that heaviness hits, go back to bed and lie down without checking whether it's working this time.
- ☐ If it happens again tonight, wait the same twenty minutes, then repeat this list from the top.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Lying there this deep into the night can feel like something in you doesn't work right. But how long it feels like you've been awake **runs, on average, about five minutes ahead of how long you really were**.
- 2** Occasional trouble falling asleep isn't rare: about half of adults go through stretches of it.
- 3** Getting out of bed doesn't erase your progress toward sleep. The drive to sleep keeps building for every hour you're awake, **not only the hours you spend in bed**.

What's normal here, even if it doesn't feel that way

KNOW

Lying there this deep into the night can feel like something in you doesn't work right. But how long it feels like you've been awake **runs, on average, about five minutes ahead of how long you really were**.

People's next-morning guesses about their time to fall asleep ran a few minutes ahead of what a sleep monitor recorded. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Occasional trouble falling asleep isn't rare: about half of adults go through stretches of it.

So there's no need to hunt for what's uniquely wrong with you tonight, since this happens to about half of adults sometimes. [Source 3](#)

What's actually working against you right now

KNOW

Trying hard to fall asleep can backfire, but usually only when something's already got your attention.

People told to fall asleep quickly took longer to drift off specifically when something loud already had their attention. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Checking your phone to see the time isn't neutral: the light itself works against you.

Specialized cells in your eyes read light and tell your brain whether it's day or night. [Source 4](#)

What actually helps once you stop just lying there

RULE

If you're still awake after about twenty minutes, **get up and do something low-key.**

Read a few pages or play quiet music, then go back to bed once you're sleepy, not on a fixed schedule. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Getting out of bed doesn't erase your progress toward sleep. The drive to sleep keeps building for every hour you're awake, **not only the hours you spend in bed.**

Sleep drive comes from hours spent awake, not from a particular spot, so it keeps building whether you're in bed or another room. [Source 4](#)

DO

Write a specific to-do list if your mind keeps circling back to tomorrow, **not a diary entry about today:** that was the version that helped people drop off faster in a monitored sleep study.

People assigned to note down tomorrow's tasks fell asleep sooner than people who wrote about things they'd already finished. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Don't count on boredom to make you sleepy. It can reveal sleepiness that's already there, but it doesn't create it.

People kept in bed with nothing to do for days on end still didn't sleep through all of it, so boredom alone wasn't enough. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Lying in bed quietly with your eyes closed is basically as good as being asleep.

ACTUALLY

It isn't: your brain runs on close to an on-off switch between sleep and wakefulness, so quiet rest with your eyes closed **doesn't give you what actual sleep does.** [Source 6](#)

MYTH

Having a drink before bed helps you sleep.

ACTUALLY

Large amounts of alcohol before bed do speed up how fast you drop off, but that's the whole trade: **the back half of the night pays for it** with disrupted, lower-quality sleep. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <https://dtg.sites.fas.harvard.edu/DANWEGNER/pub/Ansfield,%20Wegner,%20&%20Bowser%201996.pdf>
2. <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC2045712/>
3. <https://my.clevelandclinic.org/-/scassets/files/org/neurological/sleep-disorders/fact-sheets/2-insomnia.pdf?la=en>
4. <https://www.ninds.nih.gov/health-information/public-education/brain-basics/brain-basics-understanding-sleep>
5. <https://kellercenter.hankamer.baylor.edu/news/story/2018/effects-bedtime-writing>
6. https://primecc.wustl.edu/files/5815/5550/9094/Sleep_Health.pdf
7. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC5821259/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Sleeping better at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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